

CHAPTER 23 — No Longer Running

The church clock was four minutes slow.

Elias checked it against the small travel clock on the dashboard, then against the time displayed above the pharmacy across the road.

The pharmacy agreed with him.

The church did not.

“Useful,” Zoe said.

“How?”

“You said clocks create reasons to look up.”

“I also said that was not a lesson.”

“You were wrong.”

They sat inside an old blue estate car beneath the upper floor of a municipal car park. The vehicle belonged to one of Elias’s former names and smelled of damp upholstery, engine oil and the peppermint sweets he had found fused together inside the glove compartment.

The farm van waited twenty miles away beneath the quarry shelter.

A second fallback existed closer to the meeting town: a small black hatchback stored in a private garage beyond the western bus-station district, under a dormant arrangement that did not point back to the farmhouse.

They had not taken the direct road from the farmhouse.

They had crossed two villages, used a bypass in the wrong direction, changed vehicles, stopped beneath a railway bridge and approached the town from the east.

Nothing had repeated.

No vehicle had held their speed through more than two turns.

No one had entered the quarry road behind them.

No signal had left either of them since Monday evening.

At ten fifty-three, they appeared clean.

Elias did not believe in clean.

He believed in insufficient evidence of contamination.

Zoe adjusted the backpack on her lap.

The numbered folder lay inside it.

So did the hard drive.

She had refused to leave either at the farmhouse.

Elias had not argued.

That decision had become easier after the lock-up. A refuge was only secure until someone connected the correct name to the correct door. The evidence stayed with the person whose history it contained.

The car park overlooked the northern edge of Clock Square through a gap between buildings.

The square had been built when travel meant horses and redesigned by people who believed deliveries could occur without vehicles. Stone paving covered most of it. A church occupied the southern side. The North Café sat beneath a row of black timber beams opposite the clock tower. Market stalls filled the centre beneath green and white awnings.

Two pedestrian streets left the square east and west.

A narrow lane beside the café led towards its kitchen, the bakery loading area and a service road beyond the old post office.

The bus station stood one block west.

A public car park opened north.

Elias had counted five practical exits.

Six if someone was willing to cross the churchyard wall.

Seven if a delivery driver left the wrong door open.

He had not included the final possibility in Zoe's briefing.

He was trying to teach preparation, not theft.

"Say it again," he said.

Zoe looked through the windscreen.

"North Café. Eleven thirty. You sit facing the square. I sit beside you, not opposite. The backpack stays between my feet."

"Voss?"

"Likely lead. Possibly the man who covered the western road in town. Patient."

"Vale?"

"Likely the woman with the repaired heel. Records role fits."

"Reyes?"

"Dead."

The word entered the car without ceremony.

Elias continued.

"If they ask you to move?"

"No."

"If I say move now?"

"I move."

"If I tell you we're leaving and there is time?"

"I ask why."

"That is the agreement."

"Yes."

"If the meeting fails, we use the eastern arcade," he said. "Not the café lane."

"Because the lane can be closed by one vehicle."

"Yes."

"Arcade reaches the bus station."

"And the fallback vehicle is in the garage beyond the western district. Not on the obvious exit route."

"What if the arcade is blocked?"

"Churchyard."

"What if the churchyard is blocked?"

"North car park."

"What if they block everything?"

"They cannot without becoming visible."

"That wasn't the question."

"No."

Elias looked towards the square.

"Then we improvise."

Zoe rested one hand on the backpack.

"Better answer."

The clock above the pharmacy changed to ten fifty-five.

Elias opened the door.

* * *

Market day gave everyone a reason to linger.

That was why Elias had chosen it.

A fruit seller arranged oranges into pyramids that collapsed whenever a customer removed one from the wrong side. A butcher displayed handwritten prices beneath a red awning. Two women argued beside a

stall selling second-hand books while the stallholder continued reading one of them.

Children moved between adults carrying paper bags of sweets.

A dog slept beneath a table of knitted hats.

A man played accordion near the church gate with enough enthusiasm to compensate for accuracy.

The square contained witnesses without requiring attention.

Public did not mean safe.

It meant violence had to explain itself.

Elias and Zoe entered from the eastern pedestrian street at eleven twelve.

They did not walk together.

Elias stayed three paces ahead.

Not because Zoe still demanded it.

Because arriving as a tightly formed pair made them easier to hold in one field of view.

She followed close enough that nobody could move between them without being noticed.

The yellow-striped socks showed above her trainers.

Elias had advised against them.

Zoe had worn them anyway.

"They are memorable," he had said.

"So is travelling with a man who looks like he repairs boilers illegally."

"I do not look like that."

"You do in this coat."

The coat was practical.

The argument remained unresolved.

They crossed the square once without approaching the café.

Elias bought a newspaper.

Zoe stopped at the second-hand book stall and opened a paperback she did not intend to buy.

Neither looked for Voss or Vale directly.

The meeting was not an observation exercise.

The contractors knew the place and time.

Hiding from one another now would only produce four people pretending a planned encounter had happened accidentally.

At eleven eighteen, Elias saw the man he believed was Voss.

He sat inside the church porch with a folded tourist leaflet in one hand.

No glasses.

Different coat.

The same stillness.

The man was not watching Elias directly.

He was watching the square's reactions to Elias passing through it.

Zoe remained at the book stall.

Her fingers stopped turning pages.

She had seen him too.

Elias continued towards the fruit stall.

The man folded the leaflet.

No movement towards a weapon.

No signal Elias could identify.

At eleven twenty-one, Elias saw the woman he and Zoe had mapped as

likely Vale inside the North Café.

She occupied a table near the rear wall rather than the agreed northern windows. Her hair had been cut shorter. The repaired shoes were gone. A canvas shopping bag rested beneath her chair.

She had changed almost everything Zoe had previously used to recognise her except the way she read a room.

Her coffee sat untouched.

Her attention remained on the spoon beside it.

The reflective surface showed the entrance.

Zoe closed the paperback.

The stallholder looked up.

“Two pounds.”

“I was only looking.”

“That is how books start.”

Zoe examined the cover.

A girl stood in front of a school beneath a title printed in silver letters. Nothing on the cover suggested the girl would be abducted, sold, transported or required to identify professional surveillance.

The story looked concerned with exams and friendship.

Zoe placed two pound coins on the table.

Elias saw the purchase and said nothing.

She put the book into her backpack beside the folder and drive.

Something ordinary placed beside both again.

At eleven twenty-five, they entered the café.

* * *

The North Café had twelve tables, one counter and a menu that considered mayonnaise a universal solution.

A delivery driver stood near the kitchen door waiting for a signature. Three elderly men occupied the front window and disagreed about football. A mother divided one toasted sandwich between two children with the precision of a peace treaty.

The woman from the rear table remained where Zoe had expected her.

Thirty seconds after Elias and Zoe entered, the man from the church porch came through the door.

He closed it, removed his cap and looked directly at Elias for the first time.

No one spoke.

The woman gestured towards the table.

Four chairs.

Elias chose the one with the wall behind it.

Zoe sat beside him.

The backpack went between her feet.

The man sat opposite Elias.

The woman remained opposite Zoe.

No one removed a coat.

A waitress approached with a pad.

"What can I get you?"

"Tea," Elias said.

"Same," Zoe said.

The man ordered coffee.

The woman touched the untouched cup already in front of her.

"I'm fine."

The waitress looked at the four of them.

"Food?"

"No," the man said.

Zoe opened the menu.

Elias looked at her.

"What?"

"You ate."

"That was two hours ago."

The waitress waited.

"Chips," Zoe said.

"Just chips?"

"Yes."

"Any sauce?"

"No."

The waitress wrote it down. "Mayonnaise comes with them."

"I don't want mayonnaise."

"It comes in a little pot."

"Then it can remain there."

The waitress looked at Elias as though he had created the problem.
Elias said, "No mayonnaise."

The woman crossed it from the pad and left. The man watched her go.
"Good choice of location," he said.

Elias placed the folded newspaper on the table. "You came."

"You used a dead man's phone."

"You answered."

"Not directly."

"No."

The man looked at Zoe. "Voss," he said.

The woman followed. "Vale."

Zoe looked from one to the other. "I know."

Then she said the third name.

"Reyes."

The empty fourth name changed the table.

Vale placed both hands around her cup.

Voss said, "We are not here to avenge him."

Elias watched his face.

"That was not the first thing I expected you to say."

"It needed saying."

"It does not make you harmless."

"No."

Zoe looked at Elias.

The word belonged to the airport.

He did not react.

Voss continued.

"We terminated Mac's contract yesterday."

"Mac agreed?"

"No."

"Then you attempted to terminate it."

"We will not pursue the girl. We will not recover the folder or storage device. We will not provide Mac with your route."

Zoe spoke before Elias.

"You already gave him the phone."

Voss looked at her.

"We told him Elias possessed it."

"Why?"

"To prevent Mac later presenting contact as proof that we had secretly joined you."

"That sounds like an incomplete answer."

"It is."

"What is the complete one?"

Voss glanced at Vale.

She answered.

"We wanted Mac to know that if the phone became active, the contact belonged to Elias's decision, not ours. We were creating distance."

"From him?"

"From the contract."

Zoe looked down at her hands.

"People use distance when they don't want responsibility."

Vale did not defend the wording.

"Yes," she said. "Sometimes."

The waitress returned with tea, coffee and a metal cup containing cutlery.

The conversation stopped.

She placed the drinks in the wrong order.

Vale received Elias's tea.

Zoe received Voss's coffee.

Voss exchanged them silently.

The waitress left.

Zoe watched the steam rise from her mug.

"You said you're not pursuing me," she said. "What do you want?"

Voss answered.

"To prevent Mac replacing us with people who will approach this as a simple recovery."

"He already will."

"Yes."

"Then you cannot prevent it."

"No."

Vale looked towards the spoon reflecting the entrance.

"We can warn you what the next brief will look like."

Elias said, "Alive?"

"Probably," Voss replied. "Until Mac knows whether the storage device has been accessed."

Zoe's feet tightened around the backpack.

Vale noticed but did not look down.

Elias said, "Mac bought her."

Voss's face remained still.

Vale's did not.

Only a slight change in focus.

Elias continued.

"He is not her uncle. The destination was not a family handover. Cain's

organisation held her before the flight. She escaped with her personal file and a hard drive from their archive."

Voss looked at Zoe.

"Is that your understanding?"

Elias's hand moved half an inch on the table.

Zoe saw it.

He was preparing to stop the question if she wanted him to.

She answered herself.

"My file names Mac as the buyer. Helen and Brian are listed as the receiving placement. There is no adoption order. No court. No social worker."

Voss looked back at Elias.

"The grandmother?"

"An address selected through Mac's own travel channel."

"Cain?"

"Separate from the flight arrangement," Elias said. "Cain's people knew she was moving. They did not know the true route at first."

Zoe spoke before he could continue.

"Someone close to me knew it. She disappeared. I think they forced it from her."

Jackie's name remained unspoken.

Vale watched Zoe, not the backpack.

"That would fit."

"She didn't betray me."

The sentence came quickly.

Vale did not ask who Zoe meant.

"No," Vale said. "Probably not."

Zoe's eyes sharpened.

"Probably."

"It is the honest limit."

Zoe looked at the tea.

That answer hurt more than reassurance would have.

It also gave her somewhere stable to stand.

Voss said, "What is on the drive?"

"We do not know," Elias replied.

"You haven't opened it?"

"No."

"Why?"

"It is encrypted and came from a hostile archive. I am not attaching it to a networked machine until we can preserve what is on it without changing it or exposing ourselves."

Vale nodded once.

Voss looked at her.

"You agree?"

"Yes."

"You have seen this structure?"

"Not this drive."

That distinction mattered.

Elias said, "Mac's contract used company-to-company guardianship language."

Vale's gaze returned to him.

"You saw it."

"I saw enough."

"We have seen similar language on recovery jobs," Vale said.

Zoe looked up.

"What recovery jobs?"

"Adults and children moved between placements after legal disputes, protective orders, debt conflicts and custody claims."

"Were they real?"

"Some."

"And the others?"

Vale did not answer immediately.

"We did not know enough to separate them at the time."

"That sounds useful."

"No," Vale said. "It sounds culpable."

Voss looked at her for a fraction longer than before.

Vale continued.

"Mac's paperwork was designed to be technically sufficient at the point of contact and difficult to defend later. We treated that as insulation from clients who wanted privacy."

"It was insulation from the people being moved," Zoe said.

"Yes."

The chips arrived.

No mayonnaise.

The waitress had placed ketchup beside them instead.

Zoe looked at the red packet.

Elias moved it away without comment.

She ate one chip.

The ordinary action changed the table more than the confession had.

Four people discussing trafficking beneath laminated menus while a child ate because she was hungry.

The café continued around them.

Cups struck saucers.

The football argument reached a new decade.

One of the children near the window dropped a fork.

Outside, the church clock moved towards eleven thirty-eight.

* * *

Voss placed a folded sheet of paper beneath the newspaper.

"Mac will rewrite the brief," he said. "Elias will become the abductor. Zoe will become vulnerable, coerced or medically unstable. The drive will be described as stolen commercial property."

Zoe chewed.

"That already sounds like him."

"The next team will be told not to negotiate."

"What will they be told about Elias?" Vale asked.

Voss looked at him.

"The truth?"

"No," Elias said. "Something that produces the behaviour Mac wants."

Voss nodded.

"Armed. Unstable. Responsible for Reyes. Possibly responsible for the child's original abduction."

Zoe stopped eating.

"He wasn't there."

"Truth is not required for operational urgency."

"He met me at the airport."

"Yes."

"He didn't know me."

"Yes."

"He didn't take the folder."

"Yes."

Voss did not soften the answers.

Zoe placed the chip down.

"How do we prove it?"

"You cannot prove a negative quickly enough to stop a team already moving."

"Then what is the paper?"

"Names of two intermediaries Mac used when commissioning us. One handled payments. One handled number forwarding and operational communications. There is also a vehicle supplier and a solicitor who certified the guardianship documents."

Elias did not touch it.

"Why give us that?"

"Because Mac believes information moves only towards him."

Vale said, "And because warning you without changing your options would be theatre."

Elias looked at the folded paper.

"Verified?"

"Some," Voss said. "Not all."

“Which?”

“Marked.”

Zoe reached towards it.

Elias placed two fingers on the edge first.

Not stopping her.

Holding the sheet in place while she unfolded it.

She read the names.

None meant anything to her.

One company name resembled the header on a page inside her folder.

She drew the backpack closer with her feet.

Vale saw the recognition.

“Which one?”

Zoe looked at her.

“You said you don’t want the folder.”

“We don’t.”

“You looked.”

“I did.”

“That is how wanting starts.”

Vale accepted that.

Zoe folded the paper again and placed it beneath the newspaper.

Elias did not take it from her.

Voss said, “There is another matter.”

The table changed before he continued.

“We need to know that Zoe is here by choice.”

Zoe's expression closed.

Voss looked at Elias.

"Mac says you abducted her after deviating from the assigned route."

"Mac lies."

"Yes. But you killed Reyes in a prepared room and brought a thirteen-year-old to a meeting with two contractors. We would be negligent not to ask."

"You asked," Elias said.

"I am asking her."

Zoe leaned back.

"I came because the contract is about me."

"That is not the same as choosing to remain with him."

"No."

Vale spoke quietly.

"We can move to the counter. You and I. Thirty seconds. Elias remains visible."

Zoe looked at Vale.

Vale's hands remained on the table. Voss had not changed position. The café door stayed clear.

The request could be reasonable and still repeat a pattern Zoe no longer accepted.

"No."

Vale did not press.

Voss did.

"Why?"

"Because every adult who wanted to decide something about me first moved me away from the person who might disagree."

"This is not that."

"It starts the same."

"We need your answer without Elias influencing it."

"You need to believe an answer given in the arrangement you designed."

Voss looked at her.

Zoe continued.

"If I say I choose to stay beside him while he is sitting here, you can say I'm frightened of him. If I say it alone with Vale, you can call it independent. You decide which room makes me truthful."

"That is not our intention," Vale said.

"I know."

Zoe looked directly at her.

"That is why it is dangerous. You think separating us protects me."

Vale remained still.

Zoe said, "It protected Mac at the airport. It protected Cain in the house. It protected Helen and Brian every time they talked in another room. I'm not moving."

The waitress passed near the table.

Nobody spoke until she had gone.

Voss looked at Elias.

"Did you instruct her to say that?"

"No."

"Would you allow her to leave with us?"

Elias's eyes hardened.

Zoe answered before he did.

"He doesn't allow me."

Voss looked back at her.

"He stops me when the danger is immediate. He explains when it isn't. Sometimes he gets it wrong."

"Frequently," Elias said.

Zoe ignored him.

"He doesn't own the answer."

Vale lowered her eyes to the untouched coffee.

Then she said, "We remain here."

Voss looked at her.

The disagreement lasted one second.

Then he nodded.

"Here," he said.

Zoe ate another chip.

The meeting continued.

* * *

At eleven forty-three, Vale noticed the man beside the flower stall.

She did not look at him twice.

She looked instead at the fruit seller, whose attention had moved from a customer to the northern street.

A second man stood beneath the pharmacy clock with a folded raincoat over one arm despite the clear weather. A narrow navy cap sat low over his forehead, one pale stitch running across the brim.

Neither man belonged to Voss.

Neither had been in the square when Vale arrived.

She lifted her cup.

“Voss.”

One word.

Across the table, Elias’s hand flattened on the newspaper.

Zoe’s chewing slowed.

No one turned towards the square.

Voss asked, “How many?”

“Two confirmed.”

“Mac?”

“One worked a vehicle handoff on a previous contract.”

Voss did not move.

“The message.”

Vale looked at the folded intermediary sheet beneath the newspaper.

“The incoming watch was compromised.”

“You said it was isolated.”

“I thought it was.”

“Provisioned through?”

“The number-forwarding intermediary.”

The same company was already on the sheet.

Vale understood the failure before anyone said it aloud. Killing the active team channels had not mattered if the retained incoming route still passed through infrastructure Mac could see.

Elias said, “Exits?”

Voss answered without looking towards the windows.

“North street likely covered.”

Vale used the spoon to check the entrance.

"One at the flower stall. One under the pharmacy clock. Possible third inside the eastern arcade."

Voss said, "We split."

"No," Zoe replied.

He looked at her.

Voss continued as though she had not spoken.

"Vale takes Zoe through the kitchen. Elias and I leave east and draw the coverage."

"That is the move," Zoe said.

Elias looked at her.

"Explain."

"They don't need all four of us. They need us apart."

"The kitchen route is shorter," Vale said.

"It is also one door."

"There is a service road behind it."

"And who chose that route?"

"I did."

"You were the one they followed."

Vale stopped. The sentence landed because Vale already knew it was true. Mac's people had not found the town through Elias. They had found the meeting through the contractors' channel. Any route Vale had treated as private now deserved suspicion. Voss said, "Staying together reduces speed."

"It also stops them using one of us to move the others."

Zoe turned to Elias. "That includes yours."

He held her gaze. "You were supposed to reach the fallback vehicle."

"Alone."

"Yes."

"While you stayed."

"Yes."

"That is the same shape."

"It is not the same purpose."

"No," Zoe said.

"But they only need the shape."

Vale watched Elias absorb the correction without trying to win the argument. Outside, the man near the flower stall purchased nothing.

The pharmacy man moved closer to the northern pavement.

A white delivery van entered the narrow lane beside the café.

Its reversing alarm sounded twice.

Zoe looked towards the kitchen door.

The driver from earlier pushed through carrying empty bread trays. He spoke to the woman behind the counter and pointed towards the back.

The van blocked most of the service lane while unloading.

Elias followed Zoe's attention.

She said, "That."

"No."

"You haven't heard it."

"It is a delivery van."

"Yes."

"We are not stealing another vehicle."

"I didn't steal the first one."

"You started it without consent."

“That is a technical distinction.”

“It is the entire offence.”

Voss looked between them.

Vale almost smiled.

The moment lasted less than a second.

Zoe leaned towards Elias.

“The side door is open. Driver comes inside for the signed trays. The van leaves through the western service road, not the square.”

“We do not know where it goes.”

“We don’t need where. We need out.”

“It may be tracked.”

“Everything is tracked.”

Vale said, “She is right about the road. It exits behind the old post office and joins the ring road without crossing the square.”

Voss looked at her.

“You inspected it?”

“I inspect doors.”

Reyes’s old accusation existed in the silence.

Vale’s expression did not change.

Elias looked through the café window.

The man at the flower stall had moved nearer the entrance.

The pharmacy man remained in place.

A third figure appeared at the eastern arcade.

Zoe was right.

The planned exit had already become an expectation.

The delivery van was not part of anyone's plan.

That made it useful.

Elias said, "We all move together to the kitchen."

Voss shook his head.

"Four people entering a staff door confirms the route."

"Then you and Vale remain."

Vale looked at him.

"You intend to leave us with Mac's team."

"I intend to stop them seeing which vehicle moves."

Voss said, "That is not a truce."

"No," Elias replied. "It is an opportunity to prove one."

The flower-stall man entered the café.

He removed his raincoat from one arm and folded it over a chair near the door.

No weapon visible.

No urgency.

The absence of both made him more dangerous.

Vale turned her cup so the handle faced right.

A signal to Voss.

Not attack.

Decision.

Voss said, "Go."

Elias did not move.

Vale looked at Zoe.

"The service road bends left after the post office. The van will stop at a bakery depot within three miles if it follows its printed route. Do not remain inside beyond that."

"You know the company?" Zoe asked.

"I read the side panel when it reversed."

Zoe nodded.

The same ability meeting itself across the table.

Voss placed his tourist leaflet beneath the coffee saucer.

"North car park, twelve fifteen," he said to Elias. "If this clears."

"No."

"Then how do we finish?"

"We don't today."

The flower-stall man ordered tea.

The third figure entered the square from the arcade.

Elias stood.

Zoe put the final chip into her mouth, closed the backpack and slid the straps onto both shoulders.

The ordinary action concealed the decision until it had already been made.

They walked towards the counter.

Not hurried.

Not together enough to appear coordinated.

The kitchen door stood beyond the till.

A member of staff carried a tray through it and allowed the door to swing.

Elias caught it before it closed. "Staff only,"

the woman behind the counter said. "Delivery driver asked for help with the trays."

"He did?"

"No," Elias said.

Confusion bought the same second authority would have. Zoe slipped through. Elias followed. Behind them, Vale stood and walked towards the café entrance. Voss remained seated. The man with the raincoat looked towards the kitchen. Vale stepped into his path. "Excuse me," she said, lifting her cup.

Coffee crossed his shirt. He moved backwards, swearing. The café reacted. The waitress shouted. One of the elderly men stood too quickly and knocked his chair into the next table. Voss rose to help him. The room filled with movement that belonged to ordinary accident. Elias and Zoe reached the kitchen.

* * *

Steam and heat replaced the café. Vale reached the kitchen seconds behind the man with the stained shirt. Ahead of her, Elias and Zoe were already crossing towards the delivery yard. A cook stood beside the grill, shouting after them. The bread-van driver looked up from a stack of empty trays. "Can't come through here."

"Emergency," Elias said.

The driver frowned.

"What emergency?"

The stained-shirt man pushed through the kitchen door.

His folded raincoat hung over his right forearm.

Zoe pointed.

"He has a weapon."

The driver looked from Zoe to the man, then at the shape beneath the coat.

His expression changed.

He unclipped the van keys and threw them to Elias.

“Take it.”

Then he backed behind a stack of trays and pulled out his phone.

“Police.”

“Good,” Elias said.

The van’s sliding side door stood open.

Elias pulled it shut before opening the passenger door for Zoe.

The cab contained only two seats.

No room for Voss or Vale.

No room for the meeting to continue.

The stained-shirt man entered the yard.

The compact pistol appeared beneath the raincoat.

Vale had a clear route towards Elias.

A clear route towards Zoe.

A clear choice.

She hit the gunman’s forearm from the side and drove his weapon line into the brickwork.

The shot cracked into concrete.

The cook dropped behind the doorway.

The van driver disappeared behind the trays.

Vale forced the gun arm against the wall.

Voss appeared at the kitchen door as a second man came after him.

Voss turned and blocked the entrance.

Elias climbed into the driver’s seat.

The engine started.

Vale could have stepped into the lane.

Could have called the route.

Could have tried to keep Zoe there.

Instead she moved aside.

“Left after the gate,” she shouted. “Right at the second bridge.”

Elias reversed through the open gate.

The refuse-truck driver leaned on the horn.

Zoe looked towards Vale through the passenger window.

For one moment their eyes met.

No admiration.

No promise.

Recognition of a decision made in time.

The van cleared the yard.

Elias turned left.

It disappeared behind the old post office.

* * *

The delivery van handled like a cupboard on wheels.

Trays shifted behind the bulkhead at every turn. The steering resisted changes of direction and then accepted too much at once.

The lane narrowed between brick walls.

A small car entered from the opposite direction and stopped.

Elias mounted the kerb with two wheels.

The van scraped along a hedge.

The driver of the car raised both hands in outrage.

Elias continued.

Behind them, no vehicle appeared.

Not yet.

At the first junction, the road divided.

Vale had said left after the gate, then right at the second bridge.

Elias took the left.

Zoe watched the mirrors.

"You trusted her."

"I trusted the road existed."

"That isn't what I said."

"No."

The first bridge crossed a canal.

A pedestrian path ran beside it.

The second crossed railway tracks and divided into three lanes immediately afterwards.

Elias turned right.

A sign pointed towards an industrial bakery depot.

Vale had told the truth.

The delivery route carried them away from the square without passing the northern car park, bus station or eastern arcade.

Mac's team had covered the exits chosen by people arriving on foot.

They had not covered the work route used by bread.

"Three vehicles behind," Zoe said.

"Same as before?"

"Blue hatchback. White taxi. Red estate."

"Which repeats?"

"None yet."

Elias changed lanes without signalling until the final moment.

The taxi continued straight.

The red estate turned towards the railway station. The blue hatchback remained behind. Two hundred metres. Then one fifty. Zoe watched through the side mirror. "One person."

"Description?"

"Male. Cap. Keeps right hand low."

"Could be phone."

"Could be weapon."

"Yes."

The bakery depot entrance appeared ahead. A barrier controlled entry. Vale had said the van would stop there. Elias did not. He passed the entrance and continued towards a roundabout. The blue hatchback followed. "Confirmed," Zoe said.

"Yes."

"What is the plan?"

"The black hatchback."

"They are still on us."

"Yes."

"Then we cannot go near it."

"Yes."

"That is not a plan."

"It is the current problem."

Zoe looked through the windscreen.

Retail units lined the road beyond the roundabout. Furniture warehouse. Builders' merchant. Self-storage. A supermarket distribution entrance with three articulated lorries waiting to turn.

The delivery van's fuel gauge showed less than a quarter.

Zoe studied the road.

"Take the distribution entrance."

"It is controlled."

"So was the market service gate."

A lorry began turning across the traffic, blocking both directions.

Elias used the gap behind it and entered the distribution road.

The blue hatchback tried to follow.

The lorry trailer closed across its path.

For eight seconds, the pursuer disappeared.

The distribution road split.

Staff parking left.

Goods vehicles right.

A sign warned of security barriers and number-plate recording.

Elias took the staff road.

"Cameras," Zoe said.

"Yes."

"You said no record."

"We already stole a bread van in front of thirty witnesses."

"Borrowed."

"Your standards are deteriorating."

The staff road curved behind a row of parked cars and ended at a pedestrian gate.

No vehicle exit.

The blue hatchback entered the distribution road behind them.

Elias stopped beside a loading canopy.

"What are you doing?"

"Changing the problem."

He switched off the engine and took the keys.

"Backpack."

Zoe already had it.

They left the van through the passenger side because the driver's door faced the open road.

Workers in reflective jackets moved between the building and car park. Nobody looked at them twice.

A fire door opened.

Three employees came out carrying lunch bags.

Elias and Zoe joined them.

Not running.

Moving with purpose.

The blue hatchback reached the end of the staff road and stopped behind the abandoned delivery van.

The driver got out.

Zoe saw him through gaps between parked cars.

"Same one from the pharmacy," she said. "Navy cap. Pale stitch across the brim."

Elias did not ask for anything more.

“What changed around him?”

She looked at the workers.

One slowed.

A security guard near the entrance touched his radio.

A woman by a smoking shelter moved away from the approaching man.

“He doesn’t belong.”

“Good.”

“That was praise.”

“Keep moving.”

They passed through the pedestrian gate onto a public footpath beside the railway.

The man behind them called out. “Elias.”

Neither turned. He called again. “Zoe.”

Her step faltered. Elias did not touch her. “Keep moving.”

“He knows my name.”

“They all do.”

The man did not fire. Too many people. Too many cameras. Public still required violence to explain itself. A train passed behind the fence. Sound and vibration swallowed the next ten seconds. Elias and Zoe reached the road beyond the footpath and turned towards a bus stop. A local bus approached. Zoe looked at Elias. “No money?”

“Cash.”

“Route?”

“Wrong direction.”

“That seems familiar.”

They boarded. Elias paid for two fares to the final stop. The driver closed the doors. Through the rear window, the man from the

hatchback reached the footpath too late.

The bus moved into traffic.

* * *

They left the bus four stops later.

Not at the final stop.

A pedestrian tunnel passed beneath the railway and opened into a residential street on the far side of the western district. The black hatchback waited another mile away inside a private garage rented years earlier under a dormant identity.

They walked.

Zoe's legs began to slow after the first half-mile.

She did not complain.

The backpack pulled against both shoulders.

Elias noticed and held out one hand.

Zoe looked at it.

"For the bag."

"No."

"Your left shoulder is dropping."

"I know."

"It will become pain."

"I know."

He lowered his hand.

They continued.

After another hundred metres, Zoe removed the backpack and gave it to him.

Not the folder.

Not the hard drive separately.

The whole bag.

Elias took it without comment and placed one strap over his uninjured shoulder.

The transfer lasted six minutes.

At the garage entrance, he returned it before reaching for the key.

Zoe put it on again.

No ceremony.

No suggestion that temporary trust had changed ownership.

Inside the garage stood a small black hatchback covered in dust.

Elias opened the bonnet, checked the battery connection and started it.

The engine caught reluctantly.

Zoe sat in the passenger seat this time.

Not the back.

She placed the backpack between her feet.

Elias drove out through the rear lane.

They did not return to the farmhouse.

* * *

Voss left Clock Square through the churchyard when the first sirens reached the main road.

He waited in a side street three blocks away.

Seven minutes later, Vale appeared from the service-road direction with coffee across the front of her coat.

"You let them go," he said.

"Yes."

"You gave them a route."

"Yes."

"Mac's man saw."

"He was occupied."

"That is not the point."

"No."

Voss looked towards the square.

Their limited truce had lasted less than twenty minutes before requiring a choice neither had intended to make.

Vale said, "The incoming watch was compromised through the number-forwarding intermediary."

"Which means Mac saw the invitation."

"Yes."

"And knows we attended."

"Yes."

"He will classify us as hostile."

"He already did."

Voss looked at her.

"You are comfortable with that?"

"No."

"Good."

Vale removed the coffee-stained coat and folded it over one arm.

"Zoe was right."

"About separation?"

"Yes."

Voss watched a police vehicle pass.

"The request was legitimate."

"So was her refusal."

"That does not make every future decision hers."

"No."

"It does not make Elias safe."

"No."

"It does not erase Reyes."

Vale's face tightened.

"No."

Voss looked down the side street where the delivery route disappeared behind the post office.

"What did it do?"

"What?"

"Her refusal."

Vale considered the question.

"It told us what the alliance requires."

"We do not have an alliance."

"No."

"What does the truce require, then?"

"That we stop deciding her safety in rooms she is not allowed to enter."

Voss looked towards the church tower.

The clock remained four minutes slow.

"We need to disappear."

"Yes."

"Mac will search the intermediaries we gave them."

"Yes."

"He may reach the solicitor first."

"Yes."

Voss began walking.

Vale followed.

Neither mentioned whether they would contact Elias again.

Whatever came next would depend on what the evidence proved.

* * *

The black hatchback reached the coast road after two.

Elias had used enough vehicles, public transport and wrong turns to make the route impossible to describe honestly.

Rain had begun over the hills.

Thin at first.

Then steady.

Zoe sat beside him with the paperback open on her knees.

She had not read a full page.

Elias drove without navigation.

The farmhouse lay north.

He continued west.

"Where are we going?" Zoe asked.

"Not back."

"Because Mac found the meeting."

"Because Mac compromised the channel before the meeting."

"That means he can find Voss and Vale."

"Yes."

"Will they help us again?"

"I don't know."

"They did today."

"Vale did."

"Voss stayed behind too."

"Yes."

"That counts."

"It counts as today."

Zoe looked at the book.

The girl on the cover still stood in front of the school, frozen inside a problem that probably did not involve encrypted buyer ledgers.

"What did we get?" she asked.

"Names. Companies. Confirmation that Mac will replace the team."

"And a truce."

"Possibly."

"You like that word."

"It survives contact with reality."

Zoe closed the book.

"What did they get?"

"The truth about Mac's relationship to you."

"They believed it?"

“They believed enough.”

“And the drive.”

“They know it exists.”

“They already suspected.”

“Yes.”

Rain collected at the edges of the windscreen.

The wipers moved unevenly.

One blade left a clear arc.

The other smeared water across Elias’s field of view and required him to lean slightly left.

Zoe watched him do it twice.

“We need new wipers.”

“We need a new car.”

“You say that about every car.”

“Evidence supports me.”

She placed the paperback inside the backpack.

“What now?”

Elias looked at the road ahead.

The question had existed since the airport.

At first, the answer had been a destination Mac selected.

Then a cottage.

Then a farmhouse.

Every choice had been about where to remain beyond the reach of the next person searching.

The folded intermediary list sat inside Elias’s coat.

The hard drive rested beneath Zoe's feet.

Behind them, Mac had exposed the meeting and sent people into a public square.

Cain still knew more than any of them.

Jackie remained missing.

The file had explained what Zoe was to Mac.

The drive might explain what the system was to everyone else.

"We stop using refuges as the plan," Elias said.

Zoe looked at him.

"That sounds like we're going somewhere dangerous."

"Yes."

"Where?"

"Somewhere with a machine we can keep off every network while we preserve what is on the drive."

"And after?"

"We verify the names Voss gave us."

"And then?"

Elias looked through the rain.

"Then we choose who has to move."

Zoe considered that.

"We're still running."

"Yes."

"That isn't what you said yesterday."

"No."

"What changed?"

Elias glanced at her.

“The direction.”

The wipers moved again.

Ahead, the coast road divided.

One route continued west.

The other turned inland towards a city large enough to hide equipment, people and questions.

Elias took the inland road.

Zoe rested one foot against the backpack.

Not protecting it from him.

Holding it steady through the turn.

They were still being hunted.

Reyes was dead.

Voss and Vale were somewhere behind them with Mac’s attention fixed on their backs.

The farmhouse, the cottage and the old hatchback had all become places they could no longer trust.

None of that had improved.

But for the first time since the airport, the next destination had not been chosen by fear, Mac, Cain or the people following them.

Elias drove.

Zoe watched the road beside him.

They were no longer running towards safety.

They were moving towards the truth.